and Industry), was created in March 1959, only months after the revolutionary government came to power (Figure 5.1). ICAIC, David Craven suggests, "was a haven for the most flexible and open-minded figures within the Cuban government."[21] Indeed, along with music, Cuban film has probably been the most vigorously socially engaged and critic of the arts.

Figure 5.1 ICAIC headquarters, Havana, 2008

Source: Photo by Aviva Chomsky



Directors affiliated with ICAIC like Tomás Gutiérrez Alea, Humberto Solás, Pastor Vega, Sara Gómez, Julio García Espinosa, Sergio Giral, and others have produced an astonishing number, variety, and quality of films over the decades of the Revolution. Some delved into Cuba's history, exploring new angles and interpretations in light of contemporary scholarship and events. Sergio Giral's *El otro Francisco* (1975) reinterpreted a celebrated nineteenth-century Cuban abolitionist novel, *Francisco*. The novel, in the genre of *Uncle Tom's Cabin*, offered a somewhat romanticized and melodramatic approach to the evils of slavery, with the slaves as humble victims, slave-owners as cruel individuals, and abolitionists as humanitarians. The film gives us "the